

Thoughts on Furies: Looking for Homophobia in Disguise

Project Owner: Mary Rose Krouse

Peer Stakeholders: Emery Kerani, Dylan Ray, Sarah Alhusaynat

Research Questions

What proportion of the Furry fandom holds identities under the LGBTQ+ umbrella?
Could individual unfavorable or ignorant sentiments toward furies be associated with unfavorable or ignorant sentiments toward LGBTQ+ people?

Definitions

- **Furry**
Commonly known as the furry fandom or the furry community, Furry is a fandom and community centered around a common interest in a broad spectrum of art and media featuring animal characters. Furry also holds a secondary focus in self-expression and has a known overlap with the LGBTQ+ community. I am also using this word to describe the broader concept of partaking in furry fandom or identifying as a furry.
- **furry**
A furry (plural “furries”), also commonly referred to as a furry fan, is a member of the Furry fandom and community. This is a self-applied label with no universal all-encompassing definition. Typically this is a fan of art or media featuring animal characters or someone who partakes in animal-inspired cosplay.
- **LGBTQ+**
Also commonly LGBT, LGBTQIA+, Queer (caution, sometimes derogatory), etc., this adjective refers to a minority of people whose gender identity, sexual orientation, or romantic orientation does not align with the norm of cisgender, heterosexual, and hetero-romantic.
- **homophobia and transphobia**
These refer to any prejudice or oppression directed toward non-heterosexual or non-hetero-romantic people and toward non-cisgender people, respectively. LGBTQ+ people have historically faced homophobia and transphobia for failing to conform to cultural expectations around gender and sexuality.

Impact and Stakeholders

My research question is of interest to the Furry fan community more narrowly, as well as advocates of the LGBTQ+ community more broadly, as a case study of “homophobia in disguise.” Any findings will of course carry value in the interest of the Furry niche specifically, but I would like to direct the focus away slightly from Furry itself, in favor of its association with larger and more vulnerable groups as much as possible.

The audience I would like to cater to is someone who is sympathetic to the LGBTQ+ community but unfamiliar with the Furry fandom and/or its association with the LGBTQ+

community, especially if they may have or have observed unfavorable feelings toward Furry. Depending on what the data ultimately show, the intended takeaway for this audience may be that any personal or observed stigma toward Furry could be related to unchecked personal or cultural homophobia/transphobia. Furry could serve as just one example and a warning to be cautious of homophobia/transphobia in other unexpected places.

Shared Theme: Social justice and identity through text and disparity analysis

Data Sources and Access Plan

Each of the two research questions are answerable with their own two completely separate data sources.

- 1) The data source corresponding to the first question - what proportion of Furry is LGBTQ+ - is a survey conducted by the International Anthropomorphic Research Project (IARP) in 2023. Respondents are all assumed to be members of the Furry community. The survey asks about a wide variety of topics, including sexual orientation and gender identity. I have already received personal access to these data, as well as explicit consent by a prominent member of the IARP research team to use them in personal or school-related projects. The conditions I need to respect include not publishing the data, and to give credit to IARP as the data source when presenting.

IARP Website: <https://furscience.com/>

Instructor Approval Status: Approved

- 2) The data source corresponding to the second question - association between sentiment toward Furry and LGBTQ+ - will be a survey I conduct myself. The survey will assess respondents on three scales: homophobia, transphobia, and Furry unfavorability*. Data collection will need to be carried out early in order to allow time for later analysis.

Source URL: N/A

Instructor Approval Status: Approved

*This is the current name I have chosen to refer to this scale, which I am creating myself. It would be inappropriate to refer to unfavorability toward furies along the lines of "furry-phobia," because Furry itself is not a marginalized group, even if most of the people who inhabit it are.

Data Engineering Plan

I will host my database in Railway, editing and querying via Beekeeper Studio. Google Forms has a built-in feature that will automatically update a Google Sheets spreadsheet with each survey response submission. My data source will either be a one-time download of a spreadsheet of survey responses after my survey is complete or a recurring extraction of new survey responses from the sheet as the survey is still being conducted. The schema design will be simple, with likely only one table.

Planned analysis

The question of how associated individual sentiments toward Furry and the LGBTQ+ community are can be investigated through some sub-questions that can be analyzed through predictive machine learning. These questions are inverses of each other:

- 1) Is an individual's degree of stigma toward furies predictable by their homophobic and transphobic sentiments? Which specific sentiments are most predictive?
- 2) Is an individual's degree of homophobia or transphobia predictable by their sentiments toward furies? Which specific sentiments are most predictive?

Survey answers can be aggregated onto three scales for homophobia, transphobia, and Furry unfavorability.

For the first sub-question, I could perform ordinal regression with homophobia and transphobia scores as independent variables and predicted Furry unfavorability score as the dependent variable. Separately, I could perform ordinal regression with the same dependent variable, but instead of using aggregated homophobia and transphobia scores as the independent variables, using the individual questions that these scores were derived from. This could reveal which specific homophobic and transphobic attitudes are most associated with Furry unfavorability.

For the second sub-question, I could perform two separate ordinal regressions with predicted homophobia and transphobia scores as each dependent variable. Instead of using aggregated Furry unfavorability scores as the independent variable, using the individual questions that these scores were derived from. This could reveal which specific anti-Furry attitudes are most associated with each of homophobia and transphobia.

Program Integration - Five Pillars

1) Visualization and Communication

Visualization will be the main focus in my project. Not only will I be performing data analysis, but I intend to communicate my message through a coherent storyline and even an element of sculptural data art to aid the message.

The main visual centerpiece will be a physical data visualization illustrating the proportions of sexual orientation and gender identity within Furry. The rest will either be physical or generated in digital tools such as ggplot2. Although within the scope of this class, projects will be presented in the form of a poster fair, I will aim to have the materials needed to give a spoken presentation, such as in Willamette's TechBytes or a furry convention panel.

2) Analytics and Machine Learning

I can use machine learning techniques on the categorical ordinal variables from survey responses to determine associations between homophobia, transphobia, and Furry unfavorability.

3) Ethics and Responsible Use

Given that I will be soliciting data from live human respondents, I need to be very intentional about informed consent. At the beginning of my questionnaire (in the form of a Google Form), will be a page including a description of risks and intended data usage, requiring respondents to confirm consent, as well as confirming their age as 18 or older.

Additionally, I will need to confirm permission ahead of time for every location I intend to collect respondents from. I'll be wearing a tee shirt to serve the purposes of making me identifiable as someone soliciting survey responses, inviting people to ask about my survey, and providing a QR code to bring them to the Google Form.

4) Data Engineering

Google Forms has a native feature to update a Google Sheet each time a response is submitted. From there, I will manually connect my database to draw from that spreadsheet and periodically update as responses are added. The schema design will not be very complex, but it will allow for queries and a dashboard as needed.

5) Statistics and Research Design

I expect not to have a representative sample of the U.S. or world population. The places I will be conducting my survey are likely to be more liberal-leaning and favorable toward the LGBTQ+ community. I will try not to ask questions that require a representative sample, e.g. "What proportion of people hold favorable feelings toward furries?" My response goal is at least 200 responses.

Ethics and Risk Notes

Before allowing access to my questionnaire, I will need to require all respondents to confirm understanding of a written description informing them of the following:

- 1) Data usage - I will provide details on how I intend to share the data. As per course policy, I must publish my data.
- 2) Voluntariness - I will remind respondents that it is their own choice to participate in the survey. At any point before submitting their response, they may stop taking the survey. Aside from the consent form on the first page, all questions are optional; any and all can be skipped. After submission, they will not be able to withdraw their response.
- 3) Anonymity - I will make it clear that all responses will be as anonymous as possible. I will not ask for any personally identifiable information. Because responses will not be traceable to the respondent, I will not be able to remove individual responses after submission on request.
- 4) Content - I will warn respondents that my questionnaire contains potentially disturbing content, including references to anti-gay and anti-trans violence and hate, including the mention of a homophobic slur.
- 5) Uniqueness - I will insist that nobody submit more than one response, though there is nothing I can do to stop them.

Timeline and Milestones

Visualization and Communication

Data Engineering

Ethics and Responsible Use

Analytics and Machine Learning

Statistics and Research Design

Week 5 - 6/8

- Proposal ✓
- Questionnaire draft ✓

Week 6 - 6/15

- Complete survey
 - informed consent form
 - questionnaire
 - tee shirt with QR survey code ✓
 - publish Google Form
- Permission for 1st public outing (Salem Saturday market?)
- Acquire materials for first sculptural piece

Week 7 - 6/22

- Data summary
- 1st data collection public outing

- Permission for 2nd public outing (?)
- Draft full presentation
 - Storyline
 - Visualizations
- 1st visualization

Week 8 - 6/29

- 2nd data collection public outing
- Permission for 3rd public outing (?)
- Create database
 - Lay out table structure in Railway
 - Connect survey responses with recurring update

Week 9 - 7/6

- 3rd data collection public outing
- Permission for 4th public outing (?)
- 2nd Visualization

Week 10 - 7/13

- Poster rough draft
- 4th data collection public outing
- Permission for 5th public outing (Vashon Island Strawberry Festival) ✓
- Draft machine learning analysis with incomplete survey data

Week 11 - 7/20

- 5th data collection public outing
- Close survey responses Monday night
- Finish machine learning analysis
- Draft machine learning analysis results visualization (3rd Visualization)
- Write presentation

Week 12 - 7/27

- Write-up rough draft
- Continue writing presentation
- 3rd Visualization

Week 13 - 8/3

- Finish writing presentation

- Rehearse presentation
- Supplementary visualizations

Week 14 - 8/10

- Final write-up
- Poster
- Give presentation

DS3 Process and Tooling

GitHub Repo URL: <https://github.com/MaryR0se/Mary-Krouse-Capstone-Repo>

GitHub Project Board URL: <https://github.com/users/MaryR0se/projects/1>

Discord Category: Project 18: Mary

Studio Loop Plan: Studio briefs each Sunday, critiques by the end of each Thursday